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AI and Critical Thinking

How to use artificial intelligence professionally without losing critical thinking

Artificial intelligence as an assistant and work tool, not an authority accepted uncritically

Does AI make us smarter, or just faster?

Speaker

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Public affairs and strategic communications consultant

- ~20 years of experience in communications, political processes and regulatory affairs
- Founder and former Managing Director of Golin Riga (12+ years)
- Deputy Chair, LCCI Services Council and Competition Neutrality Committee
- Member, NTSP Public Security Sub-Council since 2014
- Daily user of ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, NotebookLM, Perplexity, Copilot and other AI tools
- Founder and developer, ZEVON AI Reputation Intelligence.

ZEVON analyses how AI tools describe a company or organisation, which sources they use, and how to improve accuracy, credibility and consistency in AI-generated results.

Uses AI tools daily and knows exactly where critical thinking is essential.

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From using tools to creating business value

Three levels of AI value in an organisation

1.

DEFEND

Maintain productivity

Return on Employee

Employees use AI safely and critically in their daily work

2.

EXTEND

Improve processes

Return on Investment

Teams redesign work processes with AI

3.

UPEND

Create new models

Return on Future

The organisation creates new services, products or operating models

Organisations should begin at the "Defend" level: safe, critical and high-quality use of AI in daily work.

Source: Gartner, The 3 AI Business Outcomes That Matter: ROI, ROE, ROF, 2025; Gartner framework as summarised in public materials on Defend / Extend / Upend GenAI business cases.

AI and Critical Thinking

Three main risks of using artificial intelligence

01

Cognitive offloading

cognitive offloading

Thinking is outsourced to a tool, reducing the person's own cognitive engagement.

02

Overreliance

over-reliance

A person follows AI output even when independent verification is needed.

03

Automation bias

automation bias

A tendency to place excessive trust in automatically generated recommendations or overlook errors simply because they came from a system.

Sources: Gerlich (2025), Zhai et al. (2024), Romeo & Conti (2025/2026)

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Professional audit of an AI response

1
Purpose
What am I trying to achieve?

2
Facts
What can be verified here?

3
Logic
Is the conclusion well-founded?

4
Perspectives
Which perspective is missing?

5
Applicability
Does this fit my situation?

6
Accountability
Would I put my name to this?

Sources: Paul & Elder (2020), Korosec-Serfaty et al. (2026)